

concept of breadcrumbs as navigation tools. A breadcrumb is used to denote a path to a particular directory or file. They are extremely useful as navigation aids: they not only show you where you currently are, but also denote the path you took to get there. Thus you can backtrack or head to another place on a system by following these “crumbs.” These breadcrumbs make navigation much simpler and is one of the first features you will miss going from any other OS to Vista.

The new Explorer also offers a context-sensitive taskbar on top. The taskbar offers options to the user depending upon what the user has selected—a file or a folder. For example, selecting an HTML file will reveal an “Open” button



The context sensitive taskbar

which when clicked will open the file in the default application; the button also offers a drop-down if more than one application is able to open the file type—for the specific example of an HTML file then, you would get the options to open it in Internet Explorer, or Firefox, or Opera, and if you have the programs installed, even an HTML editor. Apart from this one task of opening an item, the context-sensitive bar also offers options for printing the file, or e-mailing the file, or even burning the file to CD or DVD.

The biggest addition, however, is that of the Search tool. You can trigger a system-wide or a local search from almost everywhere under Vista. By default, Vista indexes your personal folders and e-mails, and exposes them under the Search tool. This can, of course, be changed easily; indexing, however, cannot be turned off. The Search window is present in the upper right-hand corner of each Explorer window and also in common dia-